
Beyond the Establishment-Underground Dichotomy: A Visual Network Analysis of Flemish Literary Periodicals (1966–1969)

Jan Lampaert^{*1}

¹Universiteit Gent = Ghent University = Université de Gand (UGENT) – Belgium

Abstract

The late 1960s constitute one of the most turbulent periods in Flemish literary history, marked by the proliferation of underground magazines publishing post-experimental, neorealist, and socially and politically committed poetry. Often mimeographed and independently published, they emerged from a pronounced DIY ethos that rejected the literary authority of established periodicals. These underground periodicals have received little scholarly attention. Moreover, tend to remain methodologically invisible due to a significant gap in the authoritative *Bibliography of Flemish Literary Magazines* between 1966 and 1968. One of the few accounts of this underground circuit appears in a 1980 article by Hugo Brems in the established periodical *Dietsche Warande & Belfort (DWB)*. Writing from an established institutional position as both a *DWB* literary critic and a literary historian, Brems frames these magazines as a peripheral, fragmented, and parallel circuit.

This paper revisits and challenges that view by employing visual network analysis (VNA) (Venturini et al. 2021; Jacomy 2021) of literary periodicals and published poets to map and trace the rise of the underground scene between 1966 and 1969. It builds on earlier historical network research showing how VNA serves to nuance the dominant literary-historical view of neo-avant-garde and tradition as largely separate circuits by foregrounding patterns of interconnection (Lampaert 2025). Analysis of successive annual network cross-sections reveals the rapid formation of a prominent, coherent, and durable cluster of little magazines that is intertwined with the establishment, suggesting a vibrant and historically significant underground scene. Strikingly, by 1968 the established periodicals form a more dispersed and structurally peripheral cluster, with *DWB* occupying a comparatively marginal position (Fig. 1). This paper highlights the heuristic power of VNA to trace literary dynamics with fine-grained precision, while challenging, nuancing, and refining dominant literary-historical perspectives, such as the traditional view of a central establishment opposed to a peripheral underground.

Bibliography

Jacomy, Mathieu. 2021. *Situating Visual Network Analysis*. Aalborg: Aalborg Universitetsforlag. Accessed January 16, 2024. <https://vbn.aau.dk/en/publications/situating-visual-network-analysis>.

^{*}Speaker

Lampaert, Jan. 2025a. "The Rise of the Neo-Avant-Garde: A Visual Network Analysis of Flemish Literary Magazines (1949–1959)." *International Journal of Digital Humanities* 6, no. 3 (2025): 335–67. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s42803-025-00095-8>.
Venturini, Tommaso, Mathieu Jacomy, and Pablo Jensen. 2021. "What Do We See When We Look at Networks: Visual Network Analysis, Relational Ambiguity, and Force-Directed Layouts." *Big Data & Society* 8 (1): 1–16. <https://doi.org/10.1177/20539517211018419>.

Keywords: Literary History, Visual Network Analysis, Periodical Studies

Beyond the Establishment-Underground Dichotomy:
A Visual Network Analysis of Flemish Literary Periodicals (1966–1969)

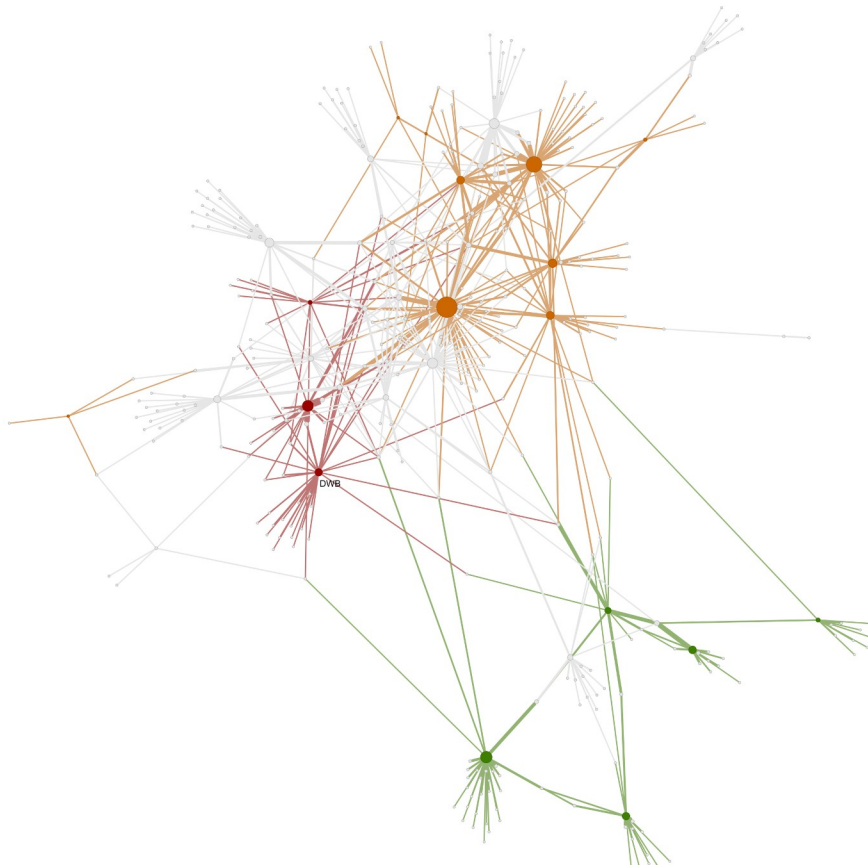


Figure 1. Network cross-section of 1968: the established periodicals are displayed in red, underground in orange.